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The New York Times



Thousands of displaced families clogged roads in Lebanon to travel back to their homes on Friday, after a cease-fire was announced.

Envoy Five Years Out of College Leading Cultural War in Europe

This article is by Michael D. Shear, Catherine Porter, Jane Bradley and Christopher F. Schuetze.

LONDON — When Samuel Samson, a senior adviser at the State Department, sat down privately with far-right German lawmakers in an office just steps from the White House, he was breaking with history.

For eight decades after World War II, America’s foreign policy establishment had usually steered clear of Germany’s hard-right parties, seeking to ensure that they never seized power again. That changed under President Trump, leading last September to Mr. Samson’s meeting with Beatrix von Storch and Joachim Paul of Alternative for Germany, or AfD — a party designated as a suspected extremist organization by German intelligence.

As the meeting evolved into a general gripe session, the AfD politicians told Mr. Samson, then 26, and several other American diplo-

Trump Pick Courts Far Right, Disrupting Ties to Establishment

mats that they feared the German government might ban their party, according to Mr. Paul and another person familiar with the conversation. The Americans railed against European regulation of social media, calling it a tool for stamping out conservative opinions. And the group discussed a bogus far-right conspiracy theory that mainstream European leaders were seeking to replace white populations with nonwhite immigrants.

“I got the impression — partly from the length of the conversation — that they were very interested in hearing from us,” Mr. Paul said in an interview. “They took a lot of notes.”

Continued on Page A6

Cease-Fire in Lebanon Sends Thousands on Uneasy Return

By CHRISTINA GOLDBAUM and HWAIDA SAAD

QASMIYEH, Lebanon — A 60-year-old woman did not know what she would find when she returned to her home in Srifa, a village in southern Lebanon.

The woman, Mona Nazal, had fled north in early March, when the war between Israel and Hezbollah reignited. She had not been back since. But as a temporary cease-fire went into effect on Friday morning, she rushed to her car and drove for six hours until she reached the village entrance.

There, her heart sank.

Along the main street, there was almost nothing left. The pharmacy was a pile of rubble. The produce shop and tobacco stores had been cleaved in half. The roof of the wheat mill had partially caved in. Not a single building was intact.

“Gone, gone, it’s all gone,” she cried, stumbling across the dusty piles of concrete in what used to be

Braving Gridlock and Ruin, but They ‘Just Want to Be Back’

her bedroom. “Where is the floor? Where are my drawers? I can’t even find a pillow.”

Ms. Nazal was one of thousands of people who flocked to Lebanon’s devastated south on Friday to take stock of their homes, as the temporary cease-fire between Israel and the Iran-backed militia Hezbollah went into effect.

The U.S.-brokered truce was welcomed with relief across Lebanon, which has been battered by Israeli airstrikes over the past six weeks in the second major war the country has endured in two years. The latest outbreak of fighting, which began last month after Hezbollah fired on Israel in solidarity with Tehran, has killed

Continued on Page A10

Stopping Drug Traffickers: A Frustrating Game of ‘Whac-a-Mole’

By ANA IONOVA and MAX BEARAK

SANTOS, Brazil — South America’s bustling seaports have never been under more watchful eyes.

They are patrolled by armed soldiers and monitored by thousands of cameras. Drones look for divers stashing cocaine onto ships. Sniffer dogs, special agents and scanners powered by artificial intelligence sweep containers stuffed with coffee and beef for signs of drugs.

Yet, the painstaking work of intercepting cocaine before it leaves South America for the rest of the world is often a futile cat-and-mouse chase.

“We discover a route, and they’ll change to another,” said Rômulo Pereira Brandão Neto, a customs agent at the Santos port in Brazil, the busiest in Latin America. “We improve our process, they improve theirs.”

South American nations have never had a more powerful arsenal of tools, from advanced technology to military might. But the authorities say they are fighting an uphill battle against deep-pocketed criminal groups that are global in scale and that reap enor-



A Colombian coca field. Despite President Trump’s smuggling crackdown, cartels are finding new ways to meet record demand.

mous windfalls from record demand for cocaine.

Vowing to crush drug trafficking, the Trump administration has struck dozens of boats off the coast of South America since last year, claiming they carried drugs to the United States. The attacks have killed at least 177 people.

But experts say much of the cocaine that winds up in American cities is actually smuggled largely aboard cargo ships, first to Central America or Mexico across the Pacific Ocean, then trafficked over the southern U.S. border.

Forging alliances with Mexican cartels, South American drug gangs are using new routes and methods to send vast amounts of cocaine to the United States, experts and officials say, while also moving huge quantities to Europe, Asia and Australia.

The many novel ways smugglers avoid detection lay bare the challenges facing South American nations trying to placate a U.S. president who has made drug smuggling a centerpiece of his Latin America policy.

The ease with which criminal groups circumvent law enforcement strategies also raises questions about how effective U.S. strikes on boats will prove in mak-

Continued on Page A8

Iran Opens Key Strait, Trump and Tehran Say, Lifting Hopes for Peace

But U.S. Signals Its Blockade Isn’t Over

This article is by Farnaz Fassihi, Peter Eavis, Pranav Baskar and Thomas Fuller.

President Trump and the Iranian foreign minister announced on Friday that the Strait of Hormuz had reopened, raising hopes that the warring nations were cooperating and negotiating toward a peace deal.

The proclamations, made on social media by both sides, propelled U.S. stock markets to record highs and sent oil prices tumbling more than 10 percent.

But the picture was muddled when Mr. Trump said that a U.S. naval blockade of Iranian ports would remain in “FULL FORCE” until there was a peace deal.

As the day wore on, Mr. Trump appeared to be negotiating a peace agreement publicly, in real time, through interviews and social media posts. He spoke of several points as fait accompli even though Iran has not publicly agreed to them.

He told Bloomberg News that Iran had agreed to suspend its nuclear program indefinitely and that Tehran would not receive any frozen assets from the United States.

In an interview with Agence France-Presse, the president said there were “no sticking points” with Iran.

In a brief phone interview with Axios, Mr. Trump said he expected a deal “in the next day or two.” And he told CBS News that Iran had “agreed to everything.”

The agreement would allow the United States to retrieve Iran’s nuclear material, he said.

“Our people, together with the Iranians, are going to work together to go get it,” he told CBS. “And then we’ll take it to the United States.”

But in comments to Iranian state media, a spokesman for Iran’s foreign ministry said Tehran had rejected the option of transferring its enriched uranium stockpile abroad.

The sum total of Mr. Trump’s disparate statements and those by Iranian officials amounted to dizzying but hopeful signs that an end to the war might be in reach.

“A GREAT AND BRILLIANT DAY FOR THE WORLD!” Mr. Trump wrote in his series of social

media posts filled with exclamation points and all-caps messages. He thanked “fantastic” Pakistani mediators and Persian Gulf states for their “great bravery.”

Three senior Iranian officials echoed Mr. Trump’s optimism, saying that Iran and the United States were finalizing a three-page memorandum of understanding that outlined a broad framework for a lasting peace deal.

The memorandum defines a 60-day period for negotiations to continue toward a deal, they said, adding that the memorandum could be signed when the United States and Iran convene for a second round of talks in Pakistan, expected to be in the next few days. A marathon first round of talks last weekend ended without agreement.

Amid the hopes for a peace agreement, there were also striking public signs of dissension among Iranian leaders.

Iran’s foreign minister, Seyed Abbas Araghchi, said in a post on X that “the passage for all commercial vessels through the Strait of Hormuz is declared completely open for the remaining period of the ceasefire.”

The opening of the strait, he said, was “in line with the ceasefire in Lebanon,” the truce that Mr. Trump announced on Thursday that quelled fighting between Israel and the Iranian-backed militia group Hezbollah.

Continued on Page A10



Riding through a devastated suburb of Beirut, Lebanon.

Preserving a 1,200-Year Archive Of When Cherry Trees Blossom

By HIROKO TABUCHI

For more than 1,200 years, Japanese noblemen, monks and bureaucrats have carefully recorded one of the most eagerly awaited days of the year — when cherry blossoms bloom in the ancient capital, Kyoto.

In recent years, a climate scientist, Yasuyuki Aono, has been the keeper of this trove of dates, one of the world’s most remarkable and longest-running climate records. Cherry trees, or sakura, are particularly sensitive to changing temperatures, and as the planet has warmed, they have bloomed earlier and earlier.

Then last summer, Professor Aono, who had meticulously updated the record year after year, died after a battle with cancer. That prompted supporters of his work to start looking for a worthy successor.

“We need help from a botanist or someone local to Kyoto, Japan!” Tuna Acisu, a data scientist at Our World in Data, posted on X this month. The key qualifications, she wrote, were scientific expertise and being “local to Arashiyama,” a district on the

Japanese Data Is Key to New Climate Studies

western outskirts of Kyoto famous for its cherry trees.

Initially, they didn’t have much luck. No other researchers at Osaka Metropolitan University, where Professor Aono worked, would be taking over his record-keeping, Hiroko Nishino, a university spokeswoman, wrote in an email.

But now, just as Kyoto sees the last of the year’s cherry blossoms, Professor Aono’s successor has been found, Ms. Acisu said. On Friday, a Tokyo-based environmental biophysicist, Genki Katata, said he had agreed to be the new custodian of the records.

“Making sure the Kyoto data lives on is a very important job,” Dr. Katata, a senior fellow at the Canon Institute for Global Studies, said in an interview from Tokyo. “I want to carry this forward for as long as I can.”

Cherry blossoms are beloved worldwide. Crowds flock to see

Continued on Page A7



NATIONAL A11-17

Train to World Cup Costs \$150

NJ Transit confirmed the price for a round-trip rail ticket, more than 10 times the regular fare.

Jesus Memes, Threats and War

The president’s volatility under pressure has made it harder for Republicans to focus on economic issues.

INTERNATIONAL A4-10

Comic Leans on His Dwarfism

Johnson Masase has found local fame, and self acceptance, through performances that play on people’s ignorance about his 3-foot-4 frame.

Shakespeare’s Last Act?

A scholar finds the site of the playwright’s London house, raising questions of what his plans were.

SPORTS B7-10

A Revival on Ice in Buffalo

Interest in the Sabres, who have made the N.H.L. playoffs for the first time in 15 years, has been surging.

BUSINESS B1-6

Pro-Trump Avatar Avalanche

A.I.-generated fake influencers have surged online in an apparent attempt to hook conservative voters.

Stocks Continue to Rally

Powered by investors’ hope of a deal with Iran and strong corporate earnings, markets are soaring.

THE MAGAZINE

Sunday Crossword

A corrected version of the puzzle will be in the news section tomorrow after an error was discovered in the grid published in this weekend’s magazine.



ARTS C1-6

Breaking Out, All Over

After his performance on “Shrinking,” Luke Tennie can be seen on “Abbott Elementary” and “The Pitt.”

The Lurid Case of D4vd

How the hunt for details and rumors in Los Angeles captivated the public even before the singer’s arrest.

TRAVEL C7-9

36 Hours in Hoi An, Vietnam

This ancient town offers timeworn architecture, tea ceremonies, modern dining and a world-class circus.

Don’t Let Scams Spoil a Trip

Shady third-party booking sites abound, but there are ways to avoid these pitfalls when you’re planning.

OPINION A18-19

Eric Alterman

